

Green Paper 03 — Viability and the Conditions for Care

Green Papers: Notes Toward Planetary Guardianship

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Abstract

This paper explores care as a viability condition. Care is often treated as a moral ideal or a personal virtue, but it is also a systemic capacity: something that requires time, attention, trust, and institutional support.

In overloaded systems, care becomes fragile. It collapses not only through cruelty, but through exhaustion, fragmentation, and the disappearance of repair. Viability, in this context, refers to the ability of people, relationships, and institutions to remain coherent enough for responsibility to be carried over time.

1. Care is not only intention

Many societies speak of care as a value. Many institutions speak of care as a principle. Individuals often hold care as an aspiration.

Yet care is not sustained by intention alone. It requires capacity: time, stability, and access to repair.

2. Viability as a quiet ethical concept

Viability means the capacity to remain alive and coherent through change. It is not perfection. It is not growth. It is the ability to continue without collapse.

3. The hidden costs of care

Care is not free. Even when it is offered lovingly, it has costs: emotional labor, time, responsibility load, and exposure to other people's distress.

4. Institutions that ask for care while removing its conditions

Many contemporary institutions demand care rhetorically while making it practically impossible.

5. Care under planetary constraint

Planetary instability changes the ethical landscape. Care is no longer only a local interpersonal matter.

6. A practical orientation

The point of this paper is not to define care. The point is to protect the conditions that allow care to remain possible.

Closing questions

- What makes care sustainable rather than heroic?
- Where does care collapse first: body, relation, or institution?
- Which institutional designs consistently produce overload?
- What forms of repair restore viability after rupture?
- How do we carry planetary responsibility without burning out?

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